



“They [Gen Z] were raised in that period of COVID where they really understood the wellness aspect... This is the generation that really reads the label”

VANSH PAHUJA

FOUNDER, SOBER, INDIA'S FIRST
NON-ALCOHOLIC DISTILLED SPIRITS



“At the core of this movement is a profound shift in values. Indian youth are more health-conscious than ever before”

SALLONI GHODAWAT

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THE NA BEER BRAND COOLBERG

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At bars in Delhi and Bengaluru, non-alcoholic gin and whiskey cocktails are increasingly appearing on bar menus so guests can “party with non-alcoholic spirits”.

“Bengaluru cafés see stronger non alcoholic uptake because of the work-from-laptop crowd. Delhi bars, especially early-evening and pre-gig hours, trend more towards low-ABV,” says Depot48’s Narula.

However, at Depot48 in Delhi, the numbers don’t scream complete sobriety, but they do whisper moderation, suggesting the balance that Gen Z wants to maintain.

Among 22–28-year-olds, “70–80% of the spend for this age group is still classic alcohol,” says Narula. “Mocktails and zero-proof drinks are growing, but they don’t dominate the bill.

Backing this argument, Vishaal Shah, co-founder of Unsobered Moe’s Art, an ABV platform, adds, “Mindful drinking, low-ABV options, and hangover-free weekends do show up, and the interest for them

is growing, but they’re working off a very small base.” In terms of business for bars, Pahuja argues that having a non-alcoholic menu helps increase the sale of alcohol.

In a group of four where one person doesn’t drink, “they are more likely to convince everybody else that ‘I know a bar where they have a fantastic cocktail programme, but they also have something for me.’ So those four people are choosing your bar... because you have an option for both.”

MATCHA OVER MARGARITA

If zero-proof spirits are building a parallel rail next to alcohol, matcha is reigning the slots where coffee, energy drinks, and even “casual mid-week” drinks used to sit.

“When we started Bree Matcha, the gap in India was very clear,” says Co-founder Siddharth Shah. “Boomers had their chai, millennials have their coffee, so matcha would find a home in Gen Z audiences.”

According to global reports,

Gen Z increasingly uses functional drinks—matcha, kombucha, and adaptogenic lattes as mood tools and social signifiers, rather than just caffeine delivery systems.

Then come the matcha “raves”.

Matcha’s dual pull—pretty and practical—tracks neatly with Gen Z’s broader beverage choices.

VIBE-FIRST, BUZZ-LATER

There is a clear rejig of priorities. As global analysts of Gen Z drink trends put it, this is a generation that “chases experiences rather than categories.”

But earlier generations did versions of this too; they just didn’t have the language. “The behaviour has evolved, the intent has changed, but the participation hasn’t disappeared,” Shah says.

So, what sits in a young Delhiite’s glass in 2030? Pahuja imagines a world where that one-in-five NA drinker in his bar becomes one-in-two. Harish envisions menus where nearly half of the listed beverages are no- or low-ABV. Siddharth Shah sees matcha not only replacing second coffees but also quietly occupying “casual alcohol moments” across the week.

Ghodawat reflects on a changing attitude just this year. “In 2026, ‘sober is the new cool’ will be more than a slogan. It will be the reality shaping how a new generation of Indians chooses to celebrate confidently, raising a glass of something clear, creative, and alcohol-free,” she says.

If the 2010s sold the fantasy of bottomless brunches and blackout nights, the 2020s are selling something subtler, something soberer: a carefully composed feed where you can down a Picante on Friday, make a 6 A.M. run club on Saturday and still post your matcha at golden hour—vibe intact, buzz optional. **BT**

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